



CRACKED: The Dinhata incident has split the Left Nandigram. Bloc leaders in Delhi described the Cooch Behar firing as a "second Nandigram" and blamed it on "CPI(M)'s intolerance" of others in the Left Front. "Being the largest party in the Front has made a section of the CPI(M) leadership arrogant," says AIFB National Secretary G. Devarajan.

Differences between the two parties have become so acute that AIFB has entered the electoral race on its own in Tripura, which goes to polls on February 23.

While fissures within the Front have become more visible than before, some do not view this as alarming. "Differences exist and they need to be sorted out," says CPI National Secretary D. Raja. Like the AIFB, associating with the CPI(M) has become a necessity for the CPI as well.

by Satarupa Bhattacharya

Small Brother is Sulking

DELHI In the ruling Left Front in West Bengal, some Leftists are obviously more equal than others. On February 5, relations between the All India Forward Bloc (AIFB), the second-largest Left Front constituent and big

brother CPI(M) came to near snapping point after police fired on a demonstration, leading to four AIFB workers being killed and dozens injured. The demonstration in Dinhata in Cooch Behar was held to press for the develop-

ment of north Bengal. AIFB West Bengal Secretary Ashok Ghosh said his party would stay in the CPI(M)-led Government out of "necessity".

The party's disenchantment with the CPI(M) increased after last year's March 14 police action against villagers in

THE **BUZZ**
OF THE WEEK

HRD Minister Arjun Singh has become so inconspicuous by his presence that these days ministry officials don't even wait for his arrival for any official function. It's as if his being there or not doesn't really matter.

VOICES



"The Shiv Sena thinks about the Marathi *manooos* (people) only during BMC elections and remembers Hindutva during Lok Sabha elections."

Raj Thackeray, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief

"After the tables turn (if BSP comes to power at the Centre), I will make sure they (Congress and BJP) are aware of the pain caused to me, my parents and relatives."

Mayawati, Uttar Pradesh chief minister

"People ask us if we are an insignificant alliance. Watch out for the Parliament demonstration. We are fighting the cause hand-in-hand with the Left partners."

Amar Singh, Samajwadi Party leader

"It's difficult to say how many more years we (Sachin Tendulkar, Rahul Dravid and V.V.S. Laxman) will play. It depends on performance. That's what matters in cricket."

Sourav Ganguly, cricketer

"I am dark, I am independent. I can talk about my relationships without worrying about my career. I think unconventional has actually started working in Bollywood."

Bipasha Basu, actor

